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Teaching Statement

I was the first in my family to pursue a graduate degree, and along the way I learned how much it matters when someone takes the time to explain things clearly. That experience shapes how I teach. My goal is to make economics clear and useful for every student, whatever their background or plans. Some of my students will go on to study economics further, while many will take what they learn into other fields. For all of them, I hope they leave my class able to look at a real-world situation, recognize the models we studied, and use them to understand what is going on.

My interest in teaching began in college. Before exams, I would gather classmates around a whiteboard and work through the concepts, math, and graphs we expected to see on the test. Around the same time, I took a Quantitative Methods course and, like almost everyone in the class, did poorly on the first exam. I changed how I studied. I worked through every step of each problem until I understood the reasoning behind it, and then practiced until the process felt natural. On the final exam, I answered every question correctly and earned the highest grade in the course, and I was appointed teaching assistant for it in the following semesters.

That experience left me with two habits that still guide my teaching. The first is being clear about what we are doing and why. Before we work through a model, I tell students what question it answers and where it fits in the course, so they know what the algebra is for. When we finish, we go back to that question and ask what the model has told us. Part of being clear is being patient. Students do not all understand an idea the same way, so I am happy to explain it more than once and from different angles. In the Intermediate Microeconomics course I currently teach, when I was explaining profit maximization for a competitive firm, for example, I first set up the problem as finding the output that maximizes profit, which happens where the derivative of profit with respect to output equals zero. I then drew a concave profit function to show that the slope is zero at the peak. For students who found the calculus less intuitive, I explained the same condition using the definition of profit as revenue minus cost. Profit is maximized when the revenue from producing one more unit just equals the cost of producing it, that is, when marginal revenue equals marginal cost. Seeing that both explanations lead to the same answer helped many students understand why the condition holds, not just how to apply it.

The second habit is learning by doing. In the same course, I ask students to solve problems in class after nearly every chapter. I check whether they have set up a utility maximization problem correctly, ask whether their answer matches their intuition, and help when they get stuck. These sessions are also how I find out where the class stands. The questions students ask and the mistakes they make tell me what to revisit, often more clearly than an exam score does, and I adjust the pace so the material stays challenging but within reach. In one session on consumer choice, for example, I asked students to find the optimal bundle for two consumers, one with Cobb-Douglas preferences and one with perfect substitutes. Each type of preference calls for a different solution method, so students first have to recognize which one they are facing. Several students tried to solve

the perfect substitutes problem the same way as the Cobb-Douglas one, setting the marginal rate of substitution equal to the price ratio. We worked through why this fails. With perfect substitutes, the marginal rate of substitution is constant, so there is usually no tangency point. Setting the two ratios equal produces either an identity, when the slopes happen to match, or a contradiction with no interior solution. Instead, students need to compare the two slopes and see that the consumer spends the entire budget on one good. Watching students work through that mistake and come out understanding why the method changes is one of the most rewarding parts of teaching.

As a teaching assistant for Statistics during my master's, I had to learn to do all of this through a screen. The course moved online during the pandemic, and many students were reluctant to ask questions in a virtual room, especially in a quantitative course where it is easy to feel lost. I kept the sessions informal, made it clear that no question was too basic, and gave students other ways to reach me when they did not want to speak up in front of the group. Before each exam, I held online review sessions where we went over the main concepts and worked through problems from the problem sets. I also shared with the professor which questions students had engaged with or struggled with most, and the professor included a similar question on the exam. Students saw that the questions they raised in review sessions mattered, which gave them a reason to come prepared and speak up. Over the semester, more of them began asking questions and taking part in the sessions.

During my Ph.D., I also served as lead teaching assistant for Principles of Microeconomics and Principles of Macroeconomics, supporting sections taught by different professors with different textbooks and pacing. Keeping track of what each section had covered took practice, but it made me better at adjusting to different groups of students. In office hours, many students struggled with the graphs for different market structures: why a firm's demand curve is flat in one market and downward sloping in another, how that affects marginal revenue, and what this means for the firm's output, price, and profit. I prepared a review sheet with the graphs for perfect competition, monopolistic competition, and monopoly side by side, and walked students through how the features of each market produce those differences. To make the graphs less abstract, I connected each market to a real-world case. For perfect competition, I used wheat farmers in Kansas. Because each farm sells essentially the same wheat as thousands of others, no single farmer can influence the price, so the demand curve each farm faces is flat and equal to marginal revenue. The moments I remember most are students working through a graph like this correctly for the first time, and students telling me later that the study strategies I suggested helped them earn the grade they were aiming for.

Helping students find study strategies that work for them has also been central to how I mentor graduate students. For the past three years, I have mentored incoming Ph.D. students during their first year in the program. We talk about how each course is going and what they find most difficult, and I share advice on how to prepare for each professor's exams, how to study, and which habits make the year more manageable. I also ask about their routines, including whether they are sleeping, eating well, exercising, and making time to see friends, because the first year is as much about building a sustainable routine as it is about mastering the material.

Whether I am in the classroom or meeting with a first-year student, what I enjoy most is the exchange. I usually leave class with more energy than I had when I walked in, especially after sessions where students answer my questions, push back on an assumption, or ask why a model works the way it does. That connection is what I value most about teaching and mentoring. When students understand the reasoning behind the tools and have practiced enough to use them on their own, they take economics with them well beyond the classroom.